India Versus China makes four broad arguments. First, while India and China at various times looked up to each other until about the fifteenth century, their modern perceptions of each other, from the late nineteenth century onward, have been largely negative including during the Covid-19 pandemic. The influence of colonial thought on their mutual perceptions but also ignorance and racism on both sides have produced feelings of disdain and disrespect. When I say Indian and Chinese perceptions, I refer largely to elite perceptions. How ordinary Indians and Chinese regard each other is mostly unknown, though they are probably far more occupied with the challenges of everyday life, even survival, than they are worried about trans-Himalayan realities. Elite perceptions matter, and it is vital that we understand them.

Secondly, differences over perimeters – the borderlands and Tibet – are at the heart of much of the India–China conflict. Some writers blame India and others China for the original quarrel. I suggest that Delhi's and Beijing's handling of the border problem between 1949 and 1962 suffered from mirror-image difficulties – hesitations in engaging on the issue; contradictions and inconsistencies when they engaged, leading to suspicions on both sides; and an inability to accept the other's basic principle on colonial boundaries (India thought colonially inherited boundaries were legitimate and China thought they were not). Differences over the border were compounded by doubts about the other's commitments on Tibet. India concluded that China had reneged on its commitments on Tibet's autonomy, and China concluded that India wanted to undo Tibet's post-1950 status. Each side also thought the other to be aggressive rather than defensive militarily. Differences over the border, Tibet, and military moves in the Himalaya continue to complicate relations.

Thirdly, if India and China had been partners internationally, they would have had a history of strategic collaboration to draw on, to balance against their negative perceptions of each other and their conflicts in the perimeters. They would have been better placed also to reassure each other when disagreements occurred. Instead, in seventy years of engagement, they have almost always been on opposite sides of world politics. They have never